

SIPRA DAS



A Leaf From Modi's Book

BHOPAL The "Modi formula" is the latest buzzword in the BJP's political lexicon in poll-bound Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. The ruling party in both the states is keen on adopting Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi's winning political formulae following his impressive third consecutive Assembly poll victory.

With development as the centrepiece of his strategy, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Raman Singh plans to take out a

vikas yatra on a custom-made rath. While rath yatras have been intimately associated with the saffron political culture at the national level, Modi was the first chief minister to use it as an electoral strategy in a state, which Singh wants to emulate by scaling the length and breadth of Chhattisgarh. His yatra will take off just after the ongoing Gram Suraj Abhiyaan, the state Government's mass contact programme to reach out to remote areas,

WINNING PLOY: (L-R) Singh, Chauhan and Modi ends on May 30.

In Madhya Pradesh, Modi's large-scale denial of tickets to sitting MLAs has caught on like wild-fire. Following a string of defeats in parliamentary and Assembly by-elections last year, BJP managed to hang on to Betul Lok Sabha seat that went to by-polls earlier this month by the skin of its teeth. But its margin of victory came down from 1.5 lakh to a modest 35,000 votes.

Even as it took a whirlwind campaign by Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan to turn the anti-incumbency tide, it is becoming clear that local resentment against sitting legislators and ministers is a major drag on the party's political fortunes. At a party meeting in Bhopal on April 22, senior partymen suggested withholding of tickets to two-thirds of sitting MLAs and ministers and introduction of fresh faces. Clearly, the poll management strategy of the party in Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh bears Modi's imprint all the way. **by Ambresh Mishra**

SIGNPOSTS

AWARDED: To Hindustani classical vocalist **Pandit Jasraj**, the Kerala Government's Swathi Thirunal Puraskar for 2007.

ARRESTED: Arun Gawli, chief of the Akhil Bharatiya Sena party, for his alleged involvement in an extortion case. He is an MLA from Byculla constituency.



APPOINTED: Ajay Chhibber as assistant secretary-general, assistant administrator of the United Nations Development Programme and director of UNDP's regional bureau for Asia and the Pacific.

DIED: Mohammad Maqbool, 65, former Union minister of state for home affairs in H.D. Deve Gowda's JD(S)-led government in 1996.

DIED: Dr Sarojini Babar, Marathi writer and former Rajya Sabha member. She was 87.

VIS-A-VIS SHARAD YADAV JD(U) leader **versus** SHAH RUKH KHAN actor and owner of IPL team Kolkata Knight Riders

“One day a person (Rahul Gandhi) spends a night in Bundelkhand (with Dalits) and the next day he is spotted at the IPL”



SAURABH SINGH

“Rahul Gandhi is a personal friend and he came (to the IPL match in Kolkata) in that capacity.”

EPILOGUE: The Indian politicians' league begins bowling bouncers at the Indian Premier League.